Module Overview & Project Allocation

COMP3050: Individual Dissertation (2025-2026)

Matthew Pike

Module Overview

Key Information

Module Information

- **Module Code**: COMP3050
- **Module Title**: Individual Dissertation
- **Credits**: 40
- **Semester**: Whole Year Module
- **Compulsory**: No [a]
- **Moodle URL**: https://moodle.nottingham.ac.uk/course/view.php?id=153530

[a] While not compulsory, completing this module is necessary if you want a degree certificate from the Ministry of Education or a BCS accredited degree.

Module Convener

- **Module Convener**: Matthew Pike
- **Email**: matthew.pike@nottingham.edu.cn
- **Office**: PMB435
- **Office Hours**: TBC

Accreditation

- Some programmes have, or have been recommended for, British Computer Society (BCS) accreditation for Chartered IT Professional (CITP).
- To meet BCS accreditation requirements, you must undertake a major individual computing project in your final year, demonstrating the following:
  - The ability to apply practical and analytical skills present in the programme as a whole;
  - Innovation and/or creativity;
  - Synthesising information to provide and evaluate a quality solution;
  - Meet a real need in a wider context;
  - Self-management and critical self-evaluation of a significant project.
- Projects must also be passed with a minimum mark of 40%. For further information, please refer to the British Computer Society Guidelines[1].

[1] BCS Accreditation Guidelines. Available at: https://www.bcs.org/media/1209/accreditation-guidelines.pdf

Ministry of Education (MoE) Requirements

- Starting from the 2021-2022 academic year, all students seeking a degree certificate from China's Ministry of Education (MoE) must complete the dissertation module.
- This requirement does not affect the issuance of your University of Nottingham degree certificate, which is administered by the UK campus.
    - You do not need to complete the dissertation module to receive your University of Nottingham degree certificate.

Programme Requirements

- Currently, the School of Computer Science at UNNC offers two undergraduate programmes:
  - BSc Computer Science (CS)
  - BSc Computer Science with Artificial Intelligence (CSAI)
- If you are pursuing a CSAI degree, you must complete a dissertation that either focuses on AI or incorporates AI components.
  - To assist you in selecting an appropriate topic, the project catalogue will indicate suitable projects for CSAI students.
- All projects must result in the production of *project artefacts*, such as code or data.
  - It is essential that these artefacts relate to computer science in some way.
  - For example, a project that is purely mathematical would not be suitable unless it is related to a computer science topic.

Project Type

Projects are broadly categorised into three types:

1. **Software Engineering**: Development of software systems using sound software engineering principles. Artefacts include source code, documentation, and possibly user manuals.
2. **Empirical Research**: Collection and analysis of data to answer a research question. Artefacts include code, data sets, and reports.
3. **Theoretical Research**: Exploration of a theoretical problem or question related to computer science. Artefacts may include code, equations, and proofs.

Deliverables (subject to change)

Autumn Semester

- **Project Proposal** (2%)
  - Overview of the scope and direction of your project.
  - Due: ~Week 4, Autumn Semester.
- **Interim Report** (8%)
  - Progress report on your project, equivalent to a chapter in your final dissertation.
  - Due: ~Week 10, Autumn Semester.

Spring Semester

- **Dissertation** (75%)
  - 40 Page (15,000 word) document detailing the work you have conducted over the year.
  - Due: ~Week 9, Spring Semester.
- **Project Demonstration** (10%)
  - Video recording providing an overview of your project.
  - Due: ~Week 10, Spring Semester.
- **Question & Answer (Q&A)** (5%)
  - Oral examination of your project.
  - Due: ~Week 11, Spring Semester.

Pros & Cons of the Module

Pros

- Great for job/internship/graduate school applications.
- Chance to explore an area of CS that interests **you**.
- Work **with** an academic supervisor.
- Potential for outstanding work to be recognised and awarded (e.g. Best Project Award, publications, etc).

Cons

- Requires significant independent work and time management (is this a con?).
  - Your supervisor will guide, not do the work for you.
- Contributes significantly to your overall degree classification.
- Challenging and requires hard work.

Project Allocation

Process

1. **Release of Project Catalogue** - Today (30 April 2025).
2. **Contact Window Period** - 30 April 2025 - 2 June 2025.
3. **Project Allocation** - 2 June 2025 - 08 Oct 2025.

1. Release of Project Catalogue

- The project catalogue is a list of project ideas from academic staff, serving as a starting point for discussion rather than specific specifications.
- Each supervisor will have four or more project ideas.
- Projects are expected to evolve and change as you work on them.
- The Project Catalogue is available on the FYP Moodle Page. All current part-1 students have been enrolled in the module.

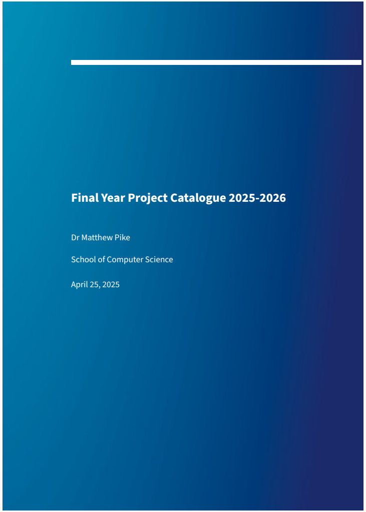

Figure 1: The Cover of this Year's Project Catalogue

2. Contact Window Period

- No formal allocation of projects will occur during this period.
- Take this opportunity to contact supervisors and discuss their projects.
- You're free to contact as many supervisors as you like, but keep in mind that you can only be allocated to one project.
- The purpose of this period is to help you make an informed decision about which project you would like to work on.

3. Project Allocation

Warning

Do not get project allocation confirmation from more than one supervisor at a time. Doing so will result in your removal from all current project allocations.

- After the Contact Window Period, the formal process of project allocation will begin, which is significantly different from the GRP project allocation process.
- Supervisors will be selecting students, rather than the other way around. This approach ensures that students are allocated to projects that suit them, as they must discuss and convince the supervisor of their suitability for the project.
- Clearly communicate your preferred project with a supervisor.
- You will receive an email from the module convenor confirming your project allocation. Your project allocation is only confirmed once you have received this email.
- An up-to-date allocation table will be maintained on the FYP Moodle Page.

Frequently Asked Questions

- **Can I work on a project that is not in the project catalogue?**
  - Yes, you can, but you must find a supervisor within Computer Science who is willing to supervise your project.
- **Can I work on a project with a supervisor who is not in the project catalogue?**
  - No, the supervisor must be from Computer Science. All supervisors in the school have been asked to submit project ideas.
- **What happens if I don't get allocated to a project?**
  - You should continue to seek a project until you reach an agreement with a supervisor. We aim to avoid situations where students are directly allocated to project.
- **What if I don't like any of the projects in the catalogue?**
  - You can propose your own project idea, but you must find a CS supervisor who is willing to supervise your project.

Why are we starting this process now?

- We start the process early to give you ample time to consider the projects and contact supervisors, ensuring a good fit between students and projects.
- Starting early also provides you with plenty of time to work on your project, which is a significant piece of work requiring substantial time and effort.
- An early project allocation allows you to begin reading around the topic and to start thinking about the project before the start of the academic year.

Next Steps

1. **Read through the project catalogue** - Make a note of any projects that interest you and do some background reading on the topics.
2. **Contact supervisors** - Initially, this should be done via email. Include the following in your message:
   - A brief introduction of yourself.
   - Why you are interested in their project.
   - Any relevant experience you have.
   - Any questions you have about the project.
3. **Repeat step 2** - Contact multiple supervisors to gain a good understanding of the available projects, identify which projects you are most interested in, and determine which supervisors you would like to work with.
4. **Identify and communicate your preferences** - After contacting supervisors, you should have a clear idea of which project you are most interested in. Communicate this to the appropriate supervisor.

Recommended Reading

Dawson, C. W. (2005). *Projects in computing and information systems: A student's guide.* Pearson Education.

Zinsser, W. K. (2001). *On writing well: The classic guide to writing nonfiction.* Quill/A Harper Collins Books.